AMERICAN SOCIOLOGICAL REVIEW

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1.1 Interview Guide

Topics

- Understanding General Change
- Revenues and Inclusivity
- Mission or Program Service Accomplishments
- Intersectional Consciousness

Interview Guide

INTERVIEW ORIENTATION

Today we'll talk about your organization's mission statement and programming//services. I'm interested in the specific vocabulary that your organization uses. I'll ask you about how the mission statement and programs were developed, how they've changed, where they stand now, and where you might see them going in the future. We'll also talk about your org's relationship with stakeholders, donors, and other people external to your org.

REASSURE PARTICIPANT OF CONFIDENTIALITY & ACQUIRE VERBAL CONSENT TO RECORD

QUESTIONS

1) I've read your organization's mission statement, and before we get started, I want to make sure I have a thorough understanding of it. **[HAVE MISSION STATEMENT TO SHARE/READ ALOUD]** Could you explain to me in your own words what your org's mission statement is?

Great, let's talk about how your organization's mission statement was developed.

2) First of all, when was the most recent time your organization changed its mission statement?
    a. What was your involvement//role in that process?
    b. What were some of the factors motivating that change?
3) Tell me about that process of changing the org's mission statement. How did that process first start?
    a. Sometimes mission statement changes and development can be smooth, other times more contentious. What was your process like?
        i. Who was involved?
        ii. What were their roles?
    b. What would you say were the main factors you//your org considered throughout the process of changing the language of your mission statement?
    c. I'd like you to think back to some of those deliberations. If I were a fly on the wall, tell me about what I would see or experience in those conversations.
        i. **PROBE:** For example, what was the atmosphere like in the room?
4) Are there any other times the org decided to change its mission statement that you're aware of?
    a. **IF NO:** SKIP TO [(5)]
    b. **IF YES:** Do you know how many changes the mission statement has undergone?
        i. **IF ONE OR 'NOT SURE/DON'T KNOW':** SKIP TO [(4) b. iii.]
        ii. **IF >ONE:** CONTINUE WITH PRIMER… I'm interested in hearing about some of the biggest or meaningful transformations that have happened. These would be

especially meaningful or even contentious changes in the mission statement. Think about one of those changes that you consider the most important or impactful.

iii. Were you involved in that process?

iv. I'm curious about how *that* change came about//what happened during *that* time. What are some of the enduring stories from that time?

5) As you know, mission statements can vary a lot from org to org. Sometimes mission statements are pragmatic and reflect what the organization is currently doing. Other times mission statements are more vision-forward and incorporate aspirational elements. What do you feel like your organization's mission statement reflects?
6) Your organization's mission statement uses the term **[[TERM OF INTEREST]]**. Do you know why the term was added or why you decided to include it?
    a. Is there another term that your organization thought about including instead of **[[TERM OF INTEREST]]**?
7) Some organizations add these terms after they've established programming for that population; others reference the population in their mission statement before they establish those services. What led your organization to choose that route that you did?
8) I want to talk a bit about diversity. Organizations can take many approaches to addressing diversity, equity, and inclusion. What language does your organization use to define//discuss//address 'diversity'?
    a. Is there any other vocabulary that your org uses?
        i. **PROBE:** For example, terms in your mission statement or words used when you declare//describe programming? Through the expansion of programming, outreach, the board of directors?
9) What, if any, conversations are your stakeholders initiating about diversity?
10) We talked about how those working for the organization deliberated on mission statement language, but when do you or other staff leaders engage with folks *outside* of your organization specifically on that language?

Speaking of external relationships, I have a few questions specifically about your interactions with donors and granting agencies.

11) In general, what do you think attracts donors to give to your organization?
12) Organizations can receive donations of many sizes; you can have donors who contribute small sums of money to benefactors who offer major gifts and endowments. What do you think attracts those *major* donors to your org?
    a. Is that different than what attracts *smaller* donors?
13) What makes up a larger portion of your revenues, major donors or small annual gifts?
14) In what ways have seen the language you use in your mission statement influence whether donors give to your organization?
15) What are your thoughts on how the mission statement language influences how *much* your donors give?
16) Sometimes donors suggest they will pull back or even cease their support if an organization's mission statement includes certain language or excludes certain language. Have you ever encountered something like this?
17) In what way, if at all, do you think the funding your org receives is related to the geographic area y'all are located?
18) When you apply for funds, what are some of the primary things you highlight to foundations//granting agencies?
    a. Are the things you highlight *different* when you apply for a grant through the government?
19) Has a foundation ever asked you to include different language, vocabulary, or programming than what you wrote or what you offer?

I have just a few more questions about your organization today and its vision for the future.

20) Some organizations, especially those in your sector, express feeling under threat in the current political or social climate; others not so much. What do you feel like your organization is experiencing right now?
    a. **IF YES THREAT:** How do you feel like the level of threat compares to what you have seen//your org has seen in the past?
    b. **IF NO THREAT:** SKIP TO [(21)]
21) Relatedly, did marriage equality have any noticeable impacts on your organization: how it does its work, whether there was a noticeable change in resources? Something like that.
22) Organizations have limited resources, and sometimes they have to decide how to distribute those resources across diverse constituencies. Tell me about a time you have had to make a decision like that.
    a. What factors influenced your decision?
    b. What was going through your mind as you weighed your options?
23) Some organizations feel that if they don't innovate the language of their mission statement, they won't survive. They express feeling a 'pressure to innovate' the language. Other orgs feel that by innovating their language, they'll be on the vanguard of a trend and can possibly increase revenues for their org. What are your thoughts on this?
24) And lastly, what would it take for your organization to change its mission statement?
    a. **PROBE:** For example, external or internal pressures, political or social shocks?

INTERVIEW SOFT CLOSE: Those are all the questions I have for you today.

25) Is there anything I didn't ask you about that I should have asked, or anything else that you want to talk about that didn't come up?
26) As we continue talking to LGBT nonprofit leaders, are there any leaders at other organizations that you would recommend we reach out to for this project?
27) Finally, would it be alright if a member of the research team reaches out to you in the event that we have any follow-up questions?

Thank you for your time! Feel free to reach out if you have any questions or concerns or you think of anything else you would like me to know.